Behavioral Inhibition as a Probabilistic Anxiety Marker

Early behavioral inhibition is associated with later social-anxiety risk at the group level; it is neither necessary nor sufficient, and stranger wariness is not a diagnosis.

MODERATE-GROUP-RISK; LOW-INDIVIDUAL-FORECAST | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: EMOTION, TEMPERAMENT | REPLICATION: VE

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Some toddlers consistently withdraw from unfamiliar people, objects, or settings. That pattern—behavioral inhibition—is a temperament risk marker for later anxiety, especially social anxiety. Clauss & Blackford (2012) meta-analyzed longitudinal studies and found elevated odds of later social-anxiety disorder among inhibited children. The association is probabilistic: most inhibited toddlers do not become clinically anxious, and anxiety occurs without an inhibited history.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

The identification is longitudinal prediction, not an RCT of temperament. Selective samples, shared informants, and reduced social opportunity can inflate estimates. Intervention trials in inhibited preschoolers (outside this card's primary ID) suggest anxiety risk can move more than observer-rated inhibition itself. Adjacent Chapter 8: stranger wariness ≠ insecure attachment. Adjacent: temperament-reactivity-not-destiny.md is the broader dimensional claim.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Odds ratios in the meta-analysis are meaningful at the group level and heterogeneous across anxiety disorders. Persistence is not identity: inhibition can recede; later anxiety can emerge without it.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: untested-in-GI (behavioral inhibition is a moderately heritable phenotype with shared genetic liability for social anxiety; individual risk forecasts are not deterministic; quantitative attenuation in twin/adoption designs not formally parameterized for this specific longitudinal link).

Shared method variance (parent report of both inhibition and later anxiety) is a live threat. Reduced exposure to novelty can maintain both the marker and the outcome.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Normative stranger anxiety, separation distress, or caution is not clinical anxiety. Early inhibition does not fix a child's future. Forcing exposure as character training, or treating a wary toddler as an attachment failure, does not follow.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Distinguish expected fear from persistent impairment across settings. Proportionate assessment when functioning is affected is consistent with the evidence. Destiny ranking is not.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Clauss & Blackford (2012), Journal of the American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry